

STATEMENT

**by H.E. Mr. Dick Schoof, Prime Minister of the
Kingdom of the Netherlands**

**General Debate of the 80th Session of the United
Nations General Assembly**

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Mr President,
Your Excellencies,
Ladies and gentlemen,

Back in 1947, a seven-year-old Dutch boy called Dirk Salomons and his father made a long car journey to the German city of Cologne.

When they arrived, Dirk couldn't believe his eyes.

'It was a shocking sight,' he said in a recent newspaper interview. 'Rubble everywhere, people living in abject poverty, the entire city flattened by bombing.'

Today, almost 80 years later, those images are still seared in Dirk's memory.

And that was precisely his father's intention.

‘He wanted to show me what war can do to a city,’ he recalled in the interview.

‘At the same time,’ he added, ‘we were also hearing radio reports about the establishment of the United Nations in New York. All my father’s hope was invested in that.’

When the interviewer asked what exactly that hope was based on, Dirk recalled the opening words of the United Nations Charter:

‘We the peoples...’

And indeed, it is the peoples of the world – the people- who task their governments with saving them from war, human rights violations and armed conflicts.

We, the peoples.

It was those words, on that day in Cologne, that inspired Dirk Salomons to embark on a career as a UN diplomat that spanned almost 30 years.

And it is those same words, 80 years on from the UN Charter, that still remind him – and us – of that task.

Of course, the world has changed dramatically since then.

And unfortunately, we must acknowledge that the mission – no more war – has failed.

In fact, this year – even as we celebrate the United Nations' 80th anniversary – we have heard it said that the UN can no longer justify its existence.

Anyone who says that, however, has forgotten where we came from.

Without the UN, there would be no disarmament treaties.

No International Court of Justice.

No climate agreements or Sustainable Development Goals.

Without the UN – which is often the only organisation capable of supplying aid in the toughest places on earth- millions of people would be deprived of food.

Clean water.

And medical aid.

Over the past 80 years, we've taken the UN's achievements for granted.

We've neglected to look back on where we've come from and all the milestones we've achieved along the way.

And although the situation right now might be especially difficult, I know this too: it has never been easy.

Every achievement was preceded by lengthy consultations.

Countries were often at loggerheads.

And sometimes it was tempting to throw in the towel.

But that never happened.

And the reason can only be that, despite our many differences, we all understand what's at stake.

That's the context in which I view the increasingly frank debate on the UN's future.

Yes, the world has changed.

Yes, international relations have changed.

And yes, the way we work together has changed.

But I believe that can lead us to only one conclusion: that we must change with the times.

And that's exactly what we're doing, through initiatives like UN80, which aims to enhance the UN's impact on the ground, simplify its structure and forge stronger partnerships with other bodies. Like international financial institutions, the private sector and philanthropic organisations.

Changing with the times, also means making the most of today's opportunities.

Such as using AI and other technologies wherever we can.

The Kingdom of the Netherlands is already taking the lead on this, by teaming up with donors and partners to explore new ways of boosting the efficiency and effectiveness of multilateral institutions.

New ways.

But not new principles.

Because the guiding principles, as laid down in the UN Charter 80 years ago, remain unchanged.

And today I'd like to reflect with you on the most important one of all...

The protection of the international legal order.

Back then, that inspired everything we stand for today.

Leading to a multilateral system of agreements.

And providing a powerful counterweight to the idea that might is right.

In my part of the world, all was well for a long time.

But now we know that this is not a given.

We've seen that in Ukraine, whose people have been suffering under Russian attacks for three and a half years now.

As Ukrainian troops continue fighting every day to protect their country, their families and their right to self-determination, people in the areas occupied by Russia are enduring systematic oppression and grave human rights violations on a daily basis.

We've seen several initiatives aimed at bringing peace closer since the spring, such as talks in Saudi Arabia, Türkiye and the US.

But peace still seems like a very distant prospect.

Ukraine has adopted a constructive stance, but so far Russia has shown no genuine willingness to accept the US proposals.

And in the meantime, the war of aggression and the suffering continue unabated.

But in case you're thinking 'there goes another European who only wants to talk about European problems', let me assure you: that is not the case. If the UN's 80 years have taught us anything, it's that all the big issues are closely interlinked.

As a Kingdom of different countries in different parts of the world, we know that better than anyone.

Take food security.

In the European part of our Kingdom, we're approaching the limits of what the earth can sustain. While the Caribbean part of the Kingdom has seen how vulnerable people are when they're dependent on others for their food security.

And then there are those other matters that we hear far too little about, even though they give cause for grave concern.

Just look at what's happening in Sudan.

Since April 2023, more than 150,000 people have been killed, and 14 million more have had to flee their homes.

All trade routes and aid corridors have been cut off, so for the past year humanitarian organisations have been unable to provide more aid.

As a result, half the Sudanese population is living with the reality of food insecurity.

And in parts of Darfur and Kordofan, a famine has been declared.

This has to stop.

The Netherlands, together with the EU and donor countries, is therefore calling on all the warring parties to respect international law and allow humanitarian aid to reach those who need it.

The Netherlands will continue supporting these humanitarian efforts for Sudan.

Not only by working via the UN and the Red Cross, but also by giving 16 million euros to the Sudan Humanitarian Fund this year.

And almost seven million euros to the Dutch Relief Alliance in Sudan.

As I've said, the horrors unfolding in Sudan have barely registered in the outside world.

The same cannot be said of the horrors unfolding in Gaza.

Every day we see more heartbreaking images emerging from the region.

Images we scarcely thought possible.

Images that defy our understanding and even our faith in humanity.

There is only one appropriate response: this war, this suffering must end now.

That starts with the safe, unimpeded and unlimited access of humanitarian aid for the suffering people of Gaza.

Including UN aid.

In addition we will continue, at both national and European level, to urge the Israeli government to drastically change its course.

For example, we're supporting the European Commission's proposal to restrict investment in Israeli companies that develop dual-use technologies.

And we're also stating clearly that we want to suspend the EU-Israel Association Agreement,

refuse goods from illegal settlements and stop issuing export licences for arms.

At the same time, these actions must not obscure another truth.

Hamas is a terrorist organisation that must lay down its arms.

There is no place for Hamas in the future governance of the Gaza Strip.

What's more, the only route to a lasting peace, is through negotiations that ultimately lead to a two-state solution.

With the signing of the New York Declaration [this High Level Week], including by the Netherlands, we are taking a step on the path to a lasting peace.

Ladies and gentlemen,

As I come to the end of my remarks, I realise – as I'm sure you do, too – how much work still needs to be done.

How many areas in which we – the UN – have fallen short.

And how long we have waited to adapt to this changing world.

So I understand that some of us may be tempted to give in to despair.

And yet, we can't allow that.

Because 80 years ago, a Dutch boy stood hand in hand with his father amid the ruins of Cologne.

And in that wasteland appeared a glimmer of hope, sparked by what had happened here in New York.

A glimmer of hope that inspired Dirk Salomons.

And his father.

And the peoples of these United Nations.

We, the peoples.

Thank you.